Silent but deadly? Physics says it depends, memory says mostly

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Abstract

The belief that a silent passage of flatus smells worse than an audible one appears in many languages but is untested. We follow a passage from sound through dispersion to a bystander's memory, with a lip-reed model of the anal valve and literature dispersion and observer models. Most sampled releases (85%) never set the valve oscillating. We prove that a slower release of the same gas cannot give a higher peak while both are carried passively by the same flow. In flow simulations of seated and standing people, the warm air rising along the body takes a slow release and lets a fast one pass, and so decides whose nose a release reaches. At physiological driving pressures, a bystander on a sofa smells audible passages more often and, when both are smelled, finds the audible one stronger twice as often as the silent one; in a closed lift the slow release rises into the breathing zone of the person behind, for whom the silent one is stronger more often (55 against 33% of pairs). Which is worse thus depends on where the noses are, and the sofa comparison lies within the combined numerical uncertainty. A silent passage is noticed only if smelled, and this selection alone can explain the belief: among remembered pairs the silent passage seems worse in 91%. It predicts that releasers believe it less firmly than bystanders and that anosmic people never remember a silent passage.

Keywords: convective boundary layer; indoor air; odour dispersion; starting jet; Berkson bias; olfactory perception; flatus

1 Introduction

The belief that a silent passage of flatus smells worse than an audible one is old. An 1811 slang dictionary defines a related term as an escape "more obvious to the nose than ears" [1], and English has called such releases "silent but deadly" since at least 1970 [2]. A documentary survey of 32 languages (Section S12) finds the distinction between silent and loud releases lexicalised in at least five language families. The claim that the silent release smells worse is stated explicitly in Chinese and English sayings, and it is built into the definitions of smell-specific "silent" words that arose independently at least four times within Indo-European. It is still current: in the film *3 Idiots* [3], a student, Chatur, nicknamed "Silencer", declares the silent release the deadliest.

We found no test of the claim. The odour of flatus is well characterised: hydrogen sulfide, methanethiol and dimethyl sulfide carry most of it [4, 5], and the volume of a passage does not predict its sulfur content [6]. Its sound has been attributed to vibration of the anal skin, like the buzzing lips of a brass player [7], but no peer-reviewed study has measured it. The only data relating sound to smell are informal and not peer reviewed: in 1 619 recorded passages, louder ones were very slightly smellier by a gas-sensor reading ($R^2 = 0.016$), and none was silent [8]. Their direction agrees with what we find, but they cannot test a claim about silent passages and human noses.

The question is narrow, but answering it needs three results that are not specific to flatus.

- *Where does a release next to a body go?* The warm convective boundary layer around a person rises along the body to the breathing zone [9, 10] and carries pollutants released

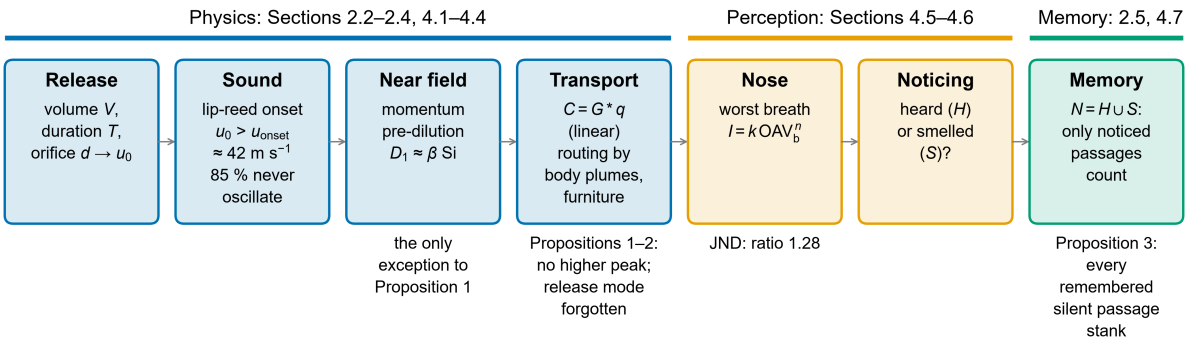


Figure 1: From release to memory: the quantity each stage passes on, and where Propositions 1–3 apply.

near the body with it [11]. Source location governs exposure when room air mixes poorly [12]; a source at a seated person's groin gives a breathing-zone intake fraction of 5–10 per mille [13]. CFD can follow particles shed from skin and clothing in this flow [14]. These studies concern passive sources and the occupant's own exposure. We show that the momentum of a release decides whether the boundary layer takes it, and so which of several nearby noses it reaches.

- *Can a slower release give a higher peak?* We prove that it cannot while both releases are carried passively by the same flow, whatever that flow is. A slower release can win only near the source: by escaping the pre-dilution of a fast jet, by at most a velocity ratio, or by being carried to a different nose.

- *How can a sensory belief be held more firmly than the physics supports?* When an event can be noticed through either of two senses, selecting the noticed events makes the two senses appear related (Berkson's bias [15, 16]). We show that this selection alone can produce the belief even where silent and audible passages are equally strong, and we derive predictions that can test this explanation.

Both halves of the claim are also ambiguous. A release can be silent because it never sets the anal valve oscillating, or because background noise masks it. "Deadlier" can mean a higher peak at a nose, a larger total dose, or a stronger memory. The comparison can be between the same gas released in two ways (equal mass), between passages as they are actually emitted, or between the passages an observer happens to notice. These bases give different answers, and we keep them apart throughout (Section 2.1).

We follow one passage from its chemistry through sound and dispersion to memory (Figure 1). Chemistry fixes which odorant carries the smell, what sets the buoyancy of a passage, and whether the odorants survive the trip to a nose. A lip-reed model of the valve gives the share of releases that are physically silent. Two propositions bound what linear transport can do to the silent/audible ratio; an analytic model of starting jets and puffs, checked against canonical jets and body plumes, gives the ratio over the range of releases; and computational fluid dynamics (CFD) of two people on a sofa, four in a lift and two standing face to face shows where the body's own airflow takes each release. A third proposition and literature models of observers give how often a remembered silent passage seems the stronger one.

2 Definitions and theory

2.1 What "deadlier" means

A passage is a release of volume V over a duration T through an effective orifice of diameter d, with exit velocity $u_0 = 4V/(\pi d^2 T)$. We take its *deadliness* for a given person to be the perceived intensity of the worst single inhalation,

$$I = k\,\mathrm{OAV}_\mathrm{b}^{n}, \qquad \mathrm{OAV}_\mathrm{b} = \max_{\text{breaths}} \frac{\int_\mathrm{insp} \dot{V}_\mathrm{insp}(t)\,\mathrm{OAV}(t)\,\mathrm{d}t}{\int_\mathrm{insp} \dot{V}_\mathrm{insp}(t)\,\mathrm{d}t}, \tag{1}$$

where $\mathrm{OAV} = \sum_i c_i/c_{\mathrm{th},i}$ is the summed odour activity value of hydrogen sulfide, methanethiol and dimethyl sulfide at the nose and n is the Stevens exponent. The breath is the natural unit: perceived intensity saturates within one natural sniff [17], still integrates within it [18], and the sniff is a unit of olfactory processing [19]. I applies only to a passage the person smells.

Every comparison below states its basis:

(A) *equal mass*: the same gas, released quietly or loudly;

(B) *as emitted*: silent and audible passages drawn from their own volume and momentum distributions, in the settings where people meet them;

(C) *as remembered*: only the passages an observer noticed.

Folk experience is basis (C). Physics answers (A) and (B). The saying is about how strong a silent passage is when it is smelled, so the physical test compares intensity, not detection: among pairs of one silent and one audible passage that a given person both smells, the share in which the silent one is stronger, the audible one is stronger, or the two cannot be told apart (concentrations within the just-noticeable ratio, Section 3.5; since I rises monotonically with OAV, this is the same as a tie in intensity). Ties are not split. How often each class is smelled at all is reported separately. On basis (C) an observer compares the passages they noticed, so a noticed passage that was not smelled counts as the weaker one.

2.2 Linear transport bounds the silent advantage

Odorants at sub-ppm levels are a passive scalar: the air carries them without being affected by them. Once the release has lost its own momentum and buoyancy, the concentration at a fixed nose is a linear functional of the release history $q(t)$ (volume of flatus per unit time):

$$C(t) = \int G(t-s)\,q(s)\,\mathrm{d}s = (G * q)(t), \qquad \int q\,\mathrm{d}s = V, \tag{2}$$

where the Green's function G encodes everything about the room, the bodies, the furniture and the ventilation. Time invariance of G requires the flow to be statistically stationary over the release, which holds for the quasi-steady convective boundary layers and room flows considered here.

Proposition 1. Let a silent release be a smoothed version of an audible one, $q_\mathrm{s} = q_\mathrm{a} * \kappa$ with $\kappa \geq 0$ and $\int \kappa = 1$. Then, for any G:

(i) the time-integrated dose $\int C\,\mathrm{d}t = V \int G$ is the same for both;

(ii) the peak concentration of the silent release does not exceed that of the audible one.

The proof (Section S3) uses only linearity and one G for both releases, and it covers the breath-averaged OAV of Eq. (1) and releases stretched by any integer factor. A quiet release can therefore be deadlier than a loud release of the same gas only where the two do not share G: near the source, where each release still shapes the flow that carries it.

2.3 Release mode is forgotten

Proposition 2. In a closed room of fluid volume V_{room} whose air mixes, so that $G(t) \to 1/V_{\text{room}}$ as $t \to \infty$, every release of volume V approaches $C = V/V_{\text{room}}$, whatever its history q, and the ratio of two release modes tends to one (proof in Section S3). Any difference between release modes is therefore carried by the early, near-field part of G.

2.4 Where the propositions fail: momentum and buoyancy

Equation (2) fails only near the source, where the release still carries its own momentum and buoyancy and so changes the flow that carries it. Two effects survive this.

Near-field pre-dilution. A momentum-dominated release entrains ambient air until its self-induced velocity has decayed to the ambient velocity u_h (the body's convective boundary layer or room air). For a starting jet, a puff or a steady jet alike, the dilution at that hand-off is

$$D_1 \approx \beta \, \frac{u_0}{u_h} \equiv \beta \, \mathrm{Si}, \qquad \beta = O(1) \tag{3}$$

(Section S4). We call the jet-to-ambient velocity ratio $\mathrm{Si} = u_0/u_h$ the *Silencer number*. With the nominal $u_h = 0.15\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, an audible release ($\mathrm{Si} > 279$, the acoustic onset) arrives pre-diluted; a slow silent one does not ($\mathrm{Si} \approx 5$ for the slow reference release of Figure 3a and 23 for the median silent release of the simulations, Section 3.4). At equal mass, pre-dilution favours the silent release by at most the ratio of the two Silencer numbers.

Routing. Momentum also sets which flow the release joins, and different flows lead to different noses. This effect can favour either release. In the rooms of Section 4.4 it changes the ratio by more than pre-dilution does.

2.5 Selection biases what is remembered

Let H be the event that a passage is heard and S the event that it is smelled. An observer can only compare passages they noticed, $N = H \cup S$.

Proposition 3. Whatever the joint law of H and S,

$$P(S \mid \neg H, N) = 1, \qquad P(S \mid H, N) = P(S \mid H). \tag{4}$$

The proof is two lines (Section S3). Among remembered passages, then, every silent one stank, while audible ones stank only at the base rate p_S, even when sound and smell are independent. The gap $1 - P(S \mid H)$ is largest when smelly passages are rare. This is Berkson's bias [15, 16]: selecting on an event that either of two causes can produce (here, noticing, produced by hearing or by smelling) makes the two causes appear related among the selected cases. Nothing in it is specific to flatus: any event noticed through either of two senses is remembered with this bias.

An observer whose noticing does not depend on smell has no such bias. The emitter, who feels every release, has N certain for all passages and so compares silent and audible releases at their true frequencies.

3 Methods

Supplementary sections, figures and tables, numbered S1, S2, ..., are in Online Resource 1. Every parameter, with its source, range and whether it is measured, derived or assumed, is listed in Table S5. Code and data are openly available (Statements and Declarations).

3.1 Source

Passage volumes span 17–375 mL [6]; the median of the 16 subjects' mean passage volumes, computed from the same data, is 92 mL. In the Monte Carlo analysis, volume V, duration T (0.3–20 s) and effective orifice diameter d (1–8 mm) are drawn log-uniformly. Neither duration nor diameter has been measured for a passage; their upper bounds come from anorectal physiology (Section S2) and the lower bounds are assumed. The driving pressure a passage needs, $\frac{1}{2}\rho(u_0/C_\mathrm{d})^2$, is limited to the largest rectal pressure rise measured while passing flatus, 88 mmHg [20]: a passage that would need more leaves at the capped velocity, about 131 m s^{-1}, over a longer time at the same volume and orifice. This slows 5% of passages, a third of the audible ones.

Sulfur gas concentrations are taken from 87 passages of 16 volunteers [4]: H_2S 1.06 µmol L^{-1}, methanethiol 0.21 µmol L^{-1} and dimethyl sulfide 0.08 µmol L^{-1}. They vary between passages by a log-normal factor with $\sigma_\mathrm{ln} = 1.1$, derived from the reported standard errors, drawn independently of volume because sulfur concentration does not correlate with passage volume [6] (a chemical explanation is in Section S11). Buoyancy, computed from measured compositions, is likewise drawn independently of volume (Spearman −0.15 across the 16 subjects).

3.2 Odorants and sound

Details are in Sections S1 and S2. Each sulfur gas contributes an odour activity value, its mole fraction over its detection threshold; the passage's OAV is their sum (no mixture suppression). We compare two measured compositions [4, 5] under three threshold sets, from a trained panel [21] to population means [22]. Gas-phase losses use IUPAC rate constants [23] and office oxidant levels [24].

The anal canal is modelled as a lip reed, a soft-tissue valve that self-oscillates in the flow through it, as the lips do on a brass instrument [7]. It oscillates when the driving pressure $\frac{1}{2}\rho(u_0/C_\mathrm{d})^2$ exceeds a threshold of 0.6–2.5 kPa, bracketed by brass playing [25] and by oesophageal and tracheo-oesophageal speech, the closest measured soft-tissue sphincter source [26–28]. This gives an onset exit velocity of about 42 m s^{-1} (21–71). An oscillating valve radiates as a harmonic monopole with a fundamental of 160 Hz (60–300 Hz). A release counts as *audible* when a harmonic exceeds both the hearing threshold [29] and the masked threshold of the background, from a 35 dB(A) living room to a 77 dB(A) subway car.

3.3 Analytic dispersion model

Dispersion is modelled in two phases. In the near field the release behaves as a starting jet and then a puff, or as a buoyant thermal, until its self-induced velocity has fallen to the ambient velocity u_h (Section S4). The cloud is then advected to the nose and spreads as a Gaussian puff, $\sigma^2 = \sigma_0^2 + 2Kt$, with indoor eddy diffusivity $K = 10^{-4}$–1.3×10^{-2} m^2 s^{-1} (measured in residences down to 10^{-3} [30]; the lowest decade is assumed for still air). Two receptors are modelled: the releaser's own nose, reached by the convective boundary layer, the layer of warm air rising along the body [9], at a speed taken from the CFD trajectories below; and a neighbour 0.8–1.4 m away, reached by room air. Concentrations are averaged over one inspiration.

We draw 20 000 pairs of silent and audible releases, each classified by the acoustic onset and evaluated with environmental parameters drawn from their ranges. Three simplifications favour the silent release: turbulent-jet constants are used even for laminar silent releases, the nose sits on the cloud centreline, and the centreline concentration is used.

3.4 Computational fluid dynamics

We use OpenFOAM 13 with transient Reynolds-averaged Navier–Stokes equations (RANS), the k–ω SST turbulence model, the Boussinesq approximation for buoyancy and the energy equation in internal-energy form.

Scenes (Section S6). Manikins built from geometric primitives, with skin at 33 °C, stand or sit in rooms at 23 °C:

- a sofa: two seated people 0.6 m apart in a 3.2 × 3.2 × 2.6 m living room, with the releaser upright, reclined by 4.5 ° or leaning forward by 10 °;
- a lift: four standing people in a closed 1.4 × 1.1 × 2.1 m car, fan off, with the releaser in the front row and a person behind;
- a standing pair: two people face to face, noses 1.0 m apart, in the same living room, in still air and with office ceiling ventilation at 2.9 air changes per hour (EN 16798-1 Category II [31]).

The upright sofa and both standing rooms are also run with long trousers on everyone: a porous shell over pelvis and thighs, 2 cm from the skin, with the air permeability of denim and open at the waist and hems.

Releases. Each room first runs 90 s without a release, until the body plumes have developed. Four representative passages are then released behind the releaser's buttocks, 30 s apart, each carried by its own passive scalar so that their doses can be read separately: the median and 90th percentile of the exit momentum flux $M_0 = \dot{Q}_0 u_0$ (volume flow rate $\dot{Q}_0 = V/T$) within each class of the source model without the pressure limit, which bracket the passages with it (silent: 122 mL over 4.8 s at $u_0 = 3.5\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, and 66 mL at $22\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$; audible: 86 mL at $94\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$, and 279 mL at $162\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$). Each enters through the same 1-cm-radius inlet with its own momentum, odorant and buoyancy fluxes, so it is pre-diluted with room air by 6.5–12 (Section S6); because momentum is conserved while a jet entrains, the dilution at the hand-off to the boundary layer, $\propto u_0/u_h$ (Eq. (3)), is unchanged. Each release is followed for 150 s. Exposure after 150 s is taken from the well-mixed room level (Proposition 2). In two 10-minute runs of the sofa (one silent and one audible 92-mL release), this level is 0.67–1.00 times the worst breath found over the full 600 s. The odorant is sampled 2.5 cm in front of each nose over sinusoidal breathing cycles.

Peak factor. RANS gives the ensemble-mean concentration, while a nose meets filaments. Large-eddy simulations (WALE subgrid model) of the upright sofa, bare and in trousers, release the four representative passages once each and the two medians a second time, and give the ratio of the large-eddy to the RANS worst breath for each release and nose.

Validation (Section S5). A free round jet reproduces the canonical decay constants to within 10–16% (grid uncertainty 3.7%); the known over-spreading of k–ω SST over-dilutes audible releases by about 15% and so favours the silent release. The convective boundary layer of a seated manikin is 40–56% faster than thermal-manikin data [9] and follows their trend with room temperature. For a source at a seated manikin's groin [13], the scene settings give a breathing-zone intake fraction of 8.1, 9.1 and 11.0 per mille over 10, 22 and 100 min, against 5.5, 7.7 and 9.8 measured. Their unheated case is not compared: without body heat the flow near the source is set by supply, lighting and aerosol temperatures that are not reported, and every scene here has heated occupants. Refining the sofa mesh by 1.5 in every direction (0.72 to 2.2 million cells) changes the median silent dose by a factor 0.55 at the neighbour and 3.0 at the releaser's own nose. A boundary layer that is too fast raises its momentum flux m_p, lowers $\Pi = M_0/m_\mathrm{p}$ (Section 4.4) and so lets it capture slow releases too readily: the simulations may understate silent doses at the neighbour on the sofa, and overstate them for the person behind the releaser in the lift, whom the captured release reaches (Section 5.4).

3.5 Perception and observers

The nose samples only during inhalation: sinusoidal flow at a conventional 12 breaths per minute (10.1 ± 3.0 measured at rest), inspiratory fraction 0.42 [32]. Perceived intensity follows Stevens' power law, $I \propto \mathrm{OAV}^n$, with $n = 0.28$ measured for the H_2S of flatus (canine flatus, rated by an

odour judge) [33]. Two passages are distinguishable when their concentrations differ by more than the olfactory Weber fraction of 0.28 [34] (coincidentally equal to n), i.e. a just-noticeable ratio of 1.28.

The OAVs of the dispersion model use trained-panel thresholds [21]. For untrained observers:

- population thresholds for H_2S and methanethiol are 10–23 times higher [22, 35];
- detection is a per-passage probability $\Phi(\log_2 \mathrm{OAV}/\sigma)$ with $\sigma = 2$ binary steps [22], since one person's threshold varies over time about as much as thresholds vary across people [36];
- a bystander who is not expecting an odour needs 26 times the threshold for a 50% response, with $\sigma = 3.5$ binary steps (Amoore's analysis [22] of the tests of ref. 37).

With the population thresholds, the attentive bystander's 50% point lies at a trained-panel OAV of 20, and the distracted bystander's at $20 \times 26 = 520$. Distraction reduces noticing [38] but did not significantly reduce the peak rated intensity [39], so intensity is computed from the attentive OAV. Two variants follow: clothing removes 22% of the sulfide gas [40], and a sound can make a distracted bystander attentive for that passage.

3.6 Uncertainty analysis

Input uncertainty is propagated through the analytic model; one multi-release CFD run costs one to several days on four to eighteen cores, too many for a sampling design. First-order Sobol indices (the share of the variance of $\log_{10} R$ explained by one input alone) are estimated by binning the Monte Carlo sample, with bootstrap 90% intervals. Because the silent and audible releases of a pair are drawn by rejection, the inputs are dependent and the indices are descriptive. The regime map shows $\log_{10} R$ at equal mass against the audible release's Silencer number and the travel time.

Passages as emitted in the simulated scenes. The 20 000 passages of the source model each have a volume V, an exit momentum flux M_0 and a class. At each nose a passage gets the dose per unit volume of the representative releases of its class, interpolated in $\log M_0$ and held constant outside their range, times V: the odorant is a passive scalar, so the dose is linear in volume, and the flow path is assumed to depend on the momentum but not on the volume. Its hearing at each nose comes from the acoustic model. Each passage is smelled with the detection probability of its OAV. Over all pairs of one silent and one audible passage, weighted by the probability that both are smelled, the intensity comparison gives the shares silent stronger (above the just-noticeable ratio), audible stronger and tie. A bystander remembers a silent passage only if smelled (Proposition 3) and an audible one whenever heard, so a remembered pair counts as "silent worse" when the silent one is stronger or the audible one was not smelled. Scenes are weighted by the time an adult spends close to another person in each setting (sofa 0.73, lift 0.005, standing 0.26; Section S8), with home- and office-centred days as bounds; a day average of a conditional share is a ratio of weighted sums, so it is dominated by the settings in which both passages are often smelled. In the clothed variants each passage is in trousers with probability 0.7 or 0.85, independently.

3.7 Use of AI-assisted tools

AI-assisted technologies (Claude Code, Anthropic) were used to write code and simulation set-ups, search the literature and draft text. The author checked all content, including every reference, and takes responsibility for it.

Table 1: Silent-to-audible concentration ratio in the analytic model (20 000 pairs).

receptor	basis	median R	5–95%	$P(R > 1)$
own nose	equal mass	1.79	0.93–11.6	0.93
own nose	as emitted	1.14	0.19–4.6	0.56
neighbour	equal mass	1.39	0.96–7.3	0.93
neighbour	as emitted	0.90	0.14–4.0	0.45
neighbour, trousers	as emitted	0.59	0.11–2.9	0.28

4 Results

4.1 The odorants and the gas that carries them

Over two measured compositions and three threshold sets, methanethiol carries 43–94% of the summed OAV and never less than H_2S (Section S1). This differs from the conclusion drawn in ref. 4, where H_2S is the main sulfur gas and the one whose concentration the judges' malodour ratings followed. Weighted by odour thresholds, the same measured concentrations give methanethiol at least an equal share: it is one fifth as concentrated, but its threshold is 5–6 times lower. Composition does not enter the silent/audible comparison, because transport is linear and acts on all three gases alike. Stevens' law with these OAVs predicts the judges' ratings of zinc-acetate-treated flatus (0.31–0.59 predicted, 0.28 and 0.59 rated) without fitting.

Composition, not temperature, sets most of the buoyancy: after cooling to room temperature 25–38% of passages are heavier than air. Gas-phase oxidation removes at most 0.4% of any odorant within 120 s (Table S1).

4.2 Most releases are physically silent

In the lip-reed model, 85% of the releases sampled never set the valve oscillating (Figure 2); the other 15% are audible in any quiet room. No release in the sampled range oscillates without being heard in a quiet room: the smallest oscillating release, about $33\,\mathrm{mL\,s^{-1}}$ through a 1 mm orifice, gives a 47 dB fundamental at sofa distance (0.6 m), against an 18 dB hearing threshold at 160 Hz. A release that is not heard is therefore either physically silent or masked by background noise.

Masking needs loud backgrounds: in a restaurant or a subway car only near-maximal passages are heard (0–13% of releases, depending on pitch). Audible releases are fast, with a median exit velocity of $88\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$.

4.3 The ratio in the analytic model

The analytic model sends every cloud to the nose, so it bounds what dilution alone can do. Table 1 gives the breath-averaged ratio $R = C_{\mathrm{silent}}/C_{\mathrm{audible}}$ for 20 000 random pairs.

Equal mass. At equal mass the audible release arrives pre-diluted by its own momentum (Eq. (3)), and the silent one is stronger at the neighbour in 93% of pairs. This is the near-field exception of Section 2.4, not a violation of Proposition 1, which holds only once the release has lost its own momentum. At the just-noticeable ratio of 1.28, the silent release is perceptibly stronger in 56% of pairs and indistinguishable in 42%.

As emitted. Audible passages are larger, and at the neighbour a silent passage is stronger in 45% of pairs: perceptibly stronger in 35%, perceptibly weaker in 45%. Trousers remove the jet momentum of both releases and lower $P(R > 1)$ to 0.28.

Which inputs matter (Figure 3b). The two passage volumes explain about two-thirds of the variance of $\log_{10} R$ as emitted; the valve parameters set whether a passage is heard, but hardly how strongly it smells.

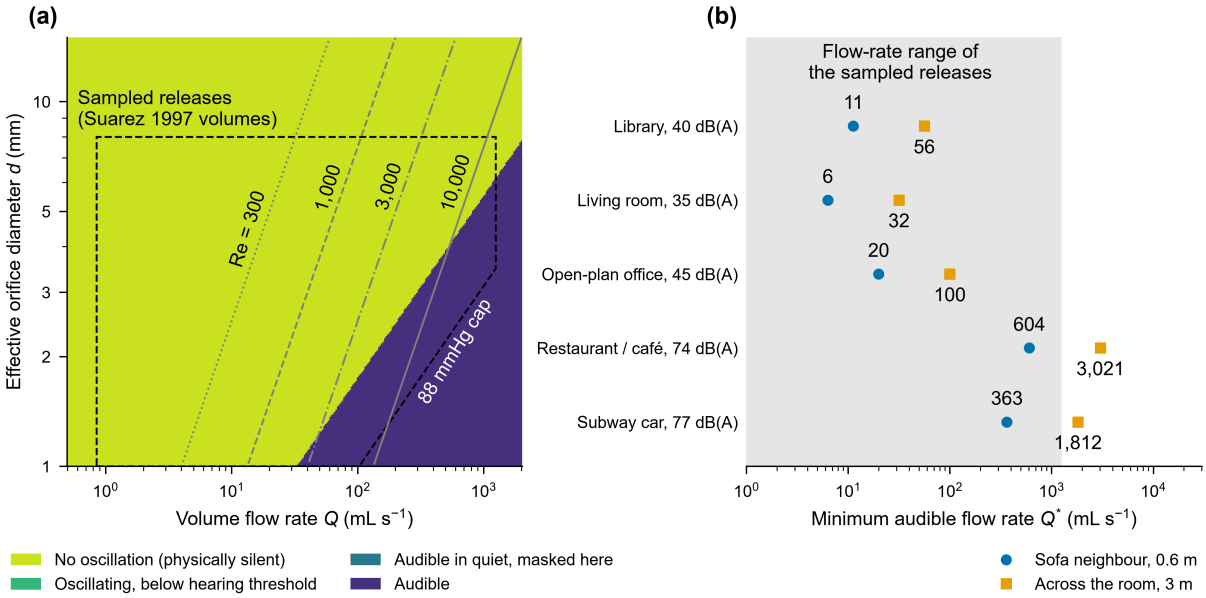


Figure 2: Acoustics. (a) Whether a release is heard, by volume flow rate and effective orifice diameter, for a neighbour at 0.6 m in a 35 dB(A) living room: the valve does not oscillate (physically silent); it oscillates but is masked here (audible in a quiet room); or it is audible. Dashed outline: the sampled range of releases, cut along the 88 mmHg driving-pressure limit. Grey lines: jet Reynolds number. (b) Minimum audible flow rate of an oscillating release for five backgrounds, at 0.6 m and 3 m. The grey band is the flow-rate range of the sampled releases. Nominal onset pressure 1.2 kPa, fundamental 160 Hz, eight harmonics.

Regime map (Figure 3a). The silent release is perceptibly stronger only at short travel times and high Silencer numbers of the audible release. At equal mass even a barely audible release is perceptibly weaker than a silent one, at the releaser's own nose (6.7 s; $R = 1.61$ at the acoustic onset) and at the neighbour (12.5 s; $R = 1.33$).

4.4 Real rooms: where the release goes

In the simulated rooms the warm air rising along the body takes a slow release with it, while a fast jet leaves it, and the two then reach different noses.

Sofa. The silent release rises along the releaser's back, over the head and to the ceiling, while the audible jet spreads along the seat to the neighbour (Figure 4a,b). At the neighbour, the worst breath over 150 s (volumes as emitted) is 0.07 and 0.09 for the two silent releases and 0.16 and 16.9 for the audible ones; reclining or leaning forward moves the silent values to 0.12–0.95, still below the trained-panel threshold. The dose rises with the ratio of the release's momentum flux to that of the boundary layer it enters, $\Pi = M_0/m_\mathrm{p}$, where m_p is the upward momentum flux of the boundary layer 15 cm above the release point: a release must break out of the boundary layer to reach a neighbour (Figure 5a).

Standing pair. Face to face and bare, the neighbour stays below OAV 0.2 for every release, in still air and with ventilation, whatever Π: the body plumes carry both clouds upwards between the two people. Momentum is therefore not the only variable; the arrangement of the bodies is the second.

Lift. In a closed car with a person behind the releaser, the silent release rises in the 0.2 m gap into that person's breathing zone (Figure 4c): worst breath 260 for the median silent release, against 36 for the strongest audible one. Every nose in the car passes OAV 1.

Releaser. At the releaser's own nose the relation is not monotonic (Figure 5b): the highest doses at equal mass, up to OAV 70, come from releases with $\Pi \approx 10$–100, which leave the seat

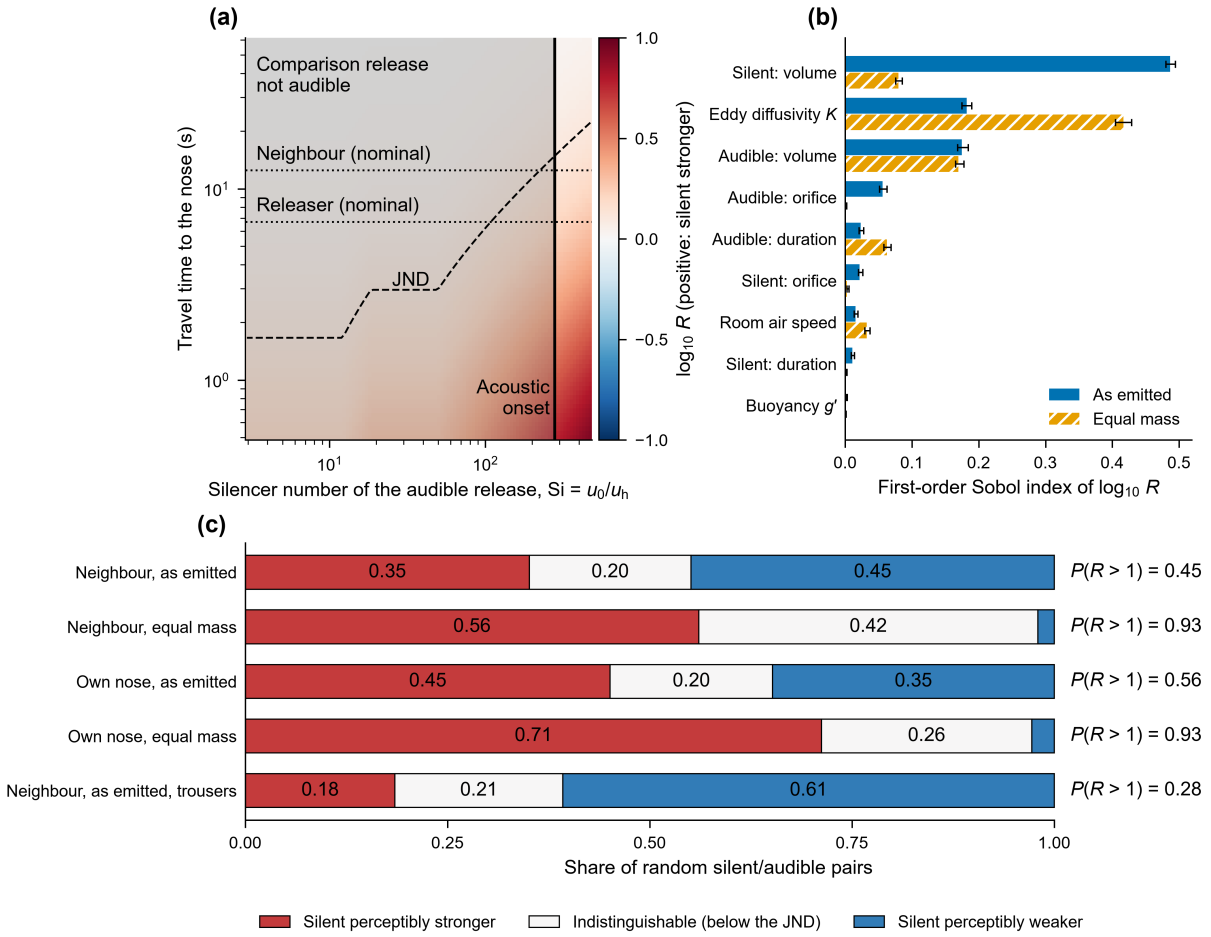


Figure 3: The ratio in the analytic model. (a) $\log_{10} R$ at equal mass and room-air mixing ($K = 10^{-3}\,\mathrm{m^2\,s^{-1}}$), over the Silencer number of the audible release and the travel time to the nose; the silent release is a reference 40 mL over 2 s through a 6-mm orifice, a slow, laminar release near the lower end of the sampled range (Si $\approx$ 5, Re $\approx$ 250). The vertical line is the acoustic onset (Si = 279); to its left the comparison release is not audible (grey). The dashed contour is the just-noticeable ratio 1.28. Dotted lines mark the nominal travel times to the releaser's (6.7 s) and the neighbour's (12.5 s) nose. (b) First-order Sobol indices of $\log_{10} R$ at the neighbour, as emitted and at equal mass, with bootstrap 90% intervals. (c) Shares of random silent/audible pairs in which the silent release is perceptibly stronger, indistinguishable, or perceptibly weaker, with $P(R > 1)$.

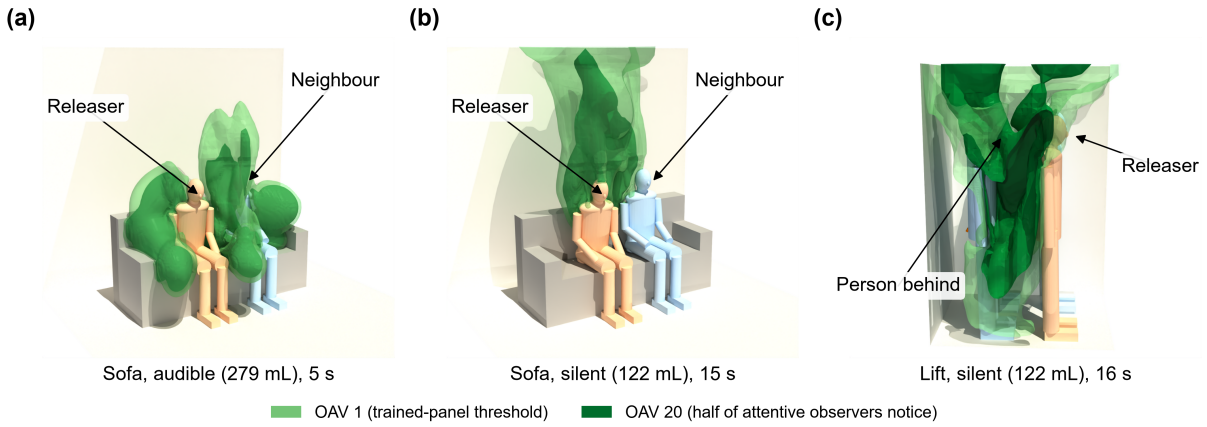


Figure 4: Where the cloud goes (RANS mean flow, volumes as emitted; light and dark green: OAV 1 and 20). (a) Sofa, releaser leaning forward, the strongest audible release 5 s after it starts: the jet spreads along the seat and reaches the neighbour's face. (b) The same sofa, the median silent release 15 s after it starts: it rises behind the heads to the ceiling. (c) Lift, the median silent release 16 s after it starts: it rises from the releaser's back into the breathing zone of the person behind.

region but stay close to the body.

4.5 Which passage is stronger when smelled

Table 2 gives, for passages as emitted, how often each class is smelled and, among pairs in which both are smelled, which is stronger. On the sofa a bystander rarely smells either, and the audible passage seven times as often as the silent one (4.1 against 0.57%). When both are smelled, which happens in 1 of about 3 000 pairs, the audible one is stronger twice as often (59 against 30%). In the closed lift the person directly behind the releaser smells both in 39% of pairs, and the silent one is the stronger more often (55 against 33%): the slow release rises along the releaser's back into that person's breathing zone. For the people beside and diagonally behind the releaser it is the reverse (31–33 against 55–56%). Between two standing people almost nothing reaches the other nose. Weighted by time, the day average is 48 against 41%; because both passages are so much more often smelled in the lift, the lift supplies three-quarters of the pairs behind this average, and home-centred days, which follow the sofa, give 32 against 57%. At the releaser's own nose the two are about equal (44 against 45%).

Robustness (Section S9, Table S4). The lift result, carried by the person behind the releaser, holds under every variation tested. The sofa result does not: the mesh-refinement factor of the releaser's nose (3.0 on every silent dose) brings it to 42 against 46%, and combined with the median large-eddy peak factors (2.2 silent, 1.3 audible) it reverses (49 against 40%), as it does with the measured release-order effect and the median peak factors (46 against 42%). The just-noticeable ratio (1.15–1.45) moves only the ties. The day average follows whichever of sofa and lift supplies more of the doubly smelled pairs, so it reverses when detection is made steeper or deterministic and without the driving-pressure limit (41 against 48%). In trousers, on the scenes run clothed (upright sofa and standing pair), the audible passage is stronger in 91% against 80% bare.

4.6 Perception

Breath sampling. For a neighbour who is not warned, the worst breath still captures 80–99% of the peak. A listener warned by the sound needs about 25 s of breath-hold for an even chance of missing the cloud (Figure S3).

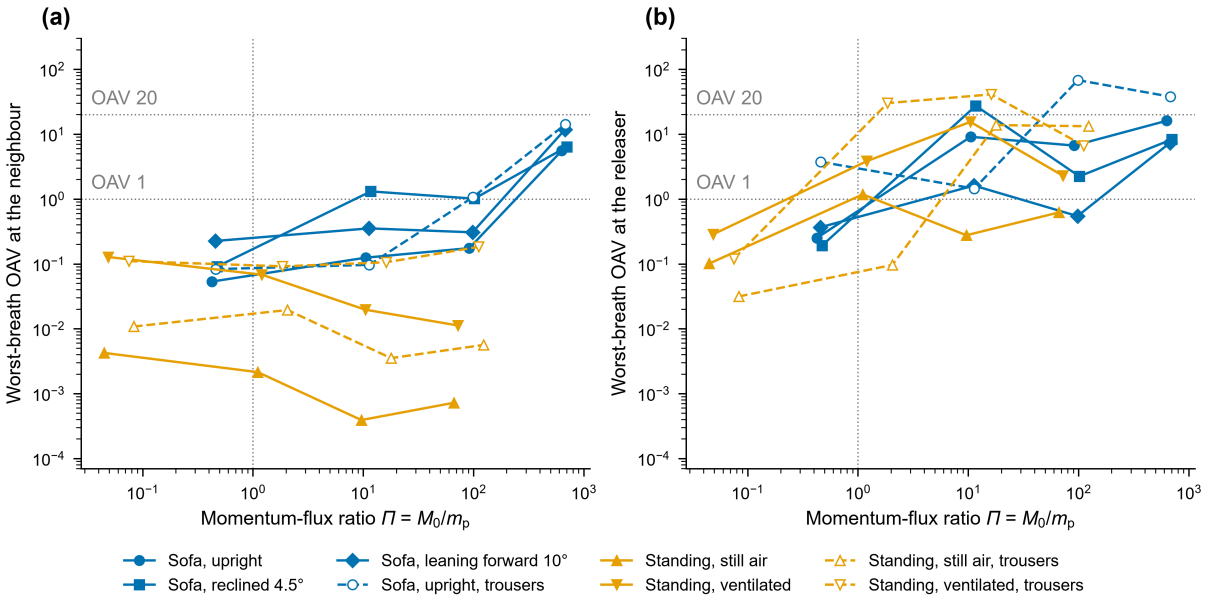


Figure 5: Routing map. Worst-breath OAV over 150 s for the same 92 mL at (a) the neighbour and (b) the releaser, against the ratio of the release's momentum flux to the upward momentum flux of the boundary layer 15 cm above the release point. Each line joins the four representative releases of one scene (left to right: the two silent and the two audible levels); filled symbols bare, open symbols trousers.

Table 2: Passages as emitted (bare, attentive observer unless stated; %). Smelled: share of silent and of audible passages smelled. Both smelled: share of silent/audible pairs in which both are smelled; the next three columns are the intensity comparison among those pairs. Remembered: share of a bystander's remembered pairs in which the silent passage seemed worse (Proposition 3). Day: settings weighted by the time spent in each (Section S8).

nose	setting	smelled		both	silent	audible	tie	remembered
		silent	audible	smelled	stronger	stronger		silent worse
bystander	sofa	0.57	4.1	0.033	30	59	12	96
	lift, behind	68	58	39	55	33	12	74
	lift, beside	4.5	11	0.51	31	56	13	92
	lift, all three	28	30	14	54	35	12	77
	standing pair	0.04	< 0.01	< 0.001	–	–	–	100
	day	0.57	3.2	0.098	48	41	12	91
	day, distracted	0.15	0.66	0.0065	51	38	11	98
releaser	day	5.2	16	0.97	44	45	11	–

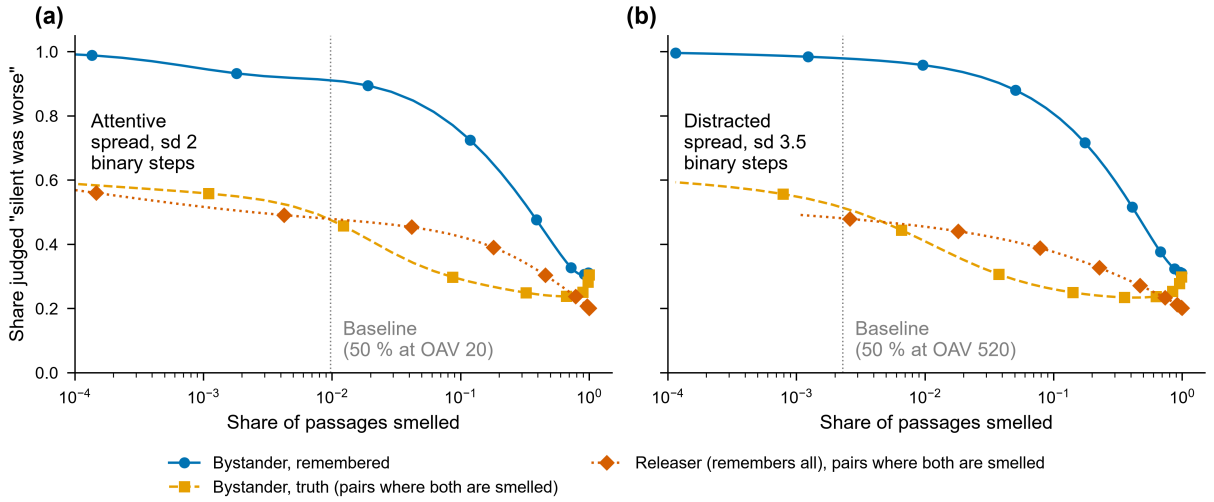


Figure 6: Memory against detection. Share of comparisons in which "the silent passage was worse", against the share of passages smelled at the nose, as the observer's 50% detection point is varied (bare, central scene weights): bystander memory (a silent passage is remembered only if smelled); the bystander truth, silent stronger by the just-noticeable ratio among pairs in which both passages are smelled; and the releaser, who notices every release, on the same criterion at the releaser's nose. Memory meets the truth, 31%, when every passage is smelled. (a) Attentive spread of the psychometric function (2 binary steps), (b) distracted (3.5). The dotted line marks the literature observer (bystander remembered 91 and 98%, truth 48 and 51%).

Expectation is not modelled. Labels change rated intensity by a few per cent for most odours [41, 42] and a health warning by 18–61% [43], but every such study announced the label, so the sign of the effect for an unwarned listener is unknown.

4.7 Memory

A bystander remembers a silent passage only if it was smelled. Among remembered pairs, the silent passage seems worse in 91% (attentive) and 98% (distracted) of comparisons (Table 2), while among pairs in which both are smelled it is stronger in 48 and 51%, and on the sofa in 30%. The remembered share is not fixed by definition: it falls as more passages are smelled and meets the truth, 31%, when every passage is smelled (Figure 6). The releaser, who notices every release, shows no selection: memory equals the physical comparison, silent stronger in about 44% of the pairs in which both are smelled.

5 Discussion

5.1 Why the belief exists

The physics we model makes silent passages neither generally worse nor generally milder. At equal mass the silent advantage at a neighbour is a median factor of 1.39 in the analytic model, often below the just-noticeable ratio, and that model sends every cloud to the nose. In the simulated rooms, with passages as emitted, the body's own airflow decides: on a sofa the audible passage is more often smelled and, when both are smelled, more often the stronger; in a closed lift the silent one is the stronger for the person behind. The lift result holds in every variation we tried; the sofa result lies within the numerical uncertainty.

The belief is nevertheless documented across languages. Proposition 3 can explain it without any physical difference: a passage enters memory if it is heard or smelled, so every remem-

bered silent passage was smelled, whereas audible passages are remembered whether or not they smelled. On the same simulated passages this selection turns a truth of 48% (day average; 30% on the sofa) into a remembered 91% (Table 2), and the gap closes only as detection approaches certainty (Figure 6). This shows that selection is sufficient for the belief, not that it is its cause; the predictions below can decide. Documented memory biases act in the same direction: distinctive pairings are over-remembered [44], and judgements built from biased samples are rarely corrected [45]. A prior verbal association alone can make people report co-occurrences that are not in what they saw [46], so the phrase itself may pass the belief on; documentary evidence cannot separate the two routes (Figure S4). Attribution may add to both: a silent passage in company usually has no known source, and a stranger's flatus disgusts more than one's own [47].

5.2 Predictions

If selection is the cause, the belief should follow who notices what, and a survey can test this.

- *Releasers.* A releaser feels every release, so their noticing does not depend on smell and Proposition 3 does not apply to their own passages. Releasers should hold the belief less firmly than bystanders. Their own passages also disgust them less: the item "silent but smells strongly" is rated 2.51 for one's own flatus and 3.71 for a stranger's on a 1–5 scale [47]. This lowers the unpleasantness of their passages, not the contrast between silent and audible ones; only an expectation about their own odour [48] could carry the belief over to them.

- *People without a sense of smell.* As bystanders they can notice a passage only by hearing it, so they never remember a silent passage. If they hold the belief, it came from the phrase, not from experience.

- *Background noise.* Masking makes quieter audible passages seem silent, so they enter memory only when smelled, while the passages still heard are the largest; the two effects oppose, so noise is not a clean test.

5.3 When a silent release is worse

At equal mass, at the releaser's own nose, in still air and within a few seconds, a silent release is perceptibly stronger than a loud one (Figure 3a). A passage deliberately slowed in company is such a case: the same gas, released quietly. The source model does not include this behaviour, so in company silent passages may be larger than as emitted. In a closed lift with someone standing behind the releaser, the slow release rises straight into that person's breathing zone, and when both passages are smelled the silent one is the stronger in 55% of pairs against 33%, in every variation tested. In these settings the saying holds. Lifts are brief in a day, but other small closed spaces in which people sit or stand close behind one another, such as cars, which we did not simulate, may behave in the same way.

5.4 Scope

The four rooms are representative rather than exhaustive, and the time spent in each is partly assumed, so the outcomes are reported per setting and the day average follows the weights (Table 2). The share of passages a bystander smells has never been measured, so the remembered share is reported against it (Figure 6). The flow path of a passage is taken to depend on its momentum and not on its volume. The simulated boundary layer is too fast, the intake fraction 1.5 times the measured one and the releaser's dose mesh-dependent (factor 3.0; Section 3.4), and the order of releases in a run changes the dose by a factor 0.4 at the neighbour and 0.8 at the releaser (Section S5). Combined, the mesh factor and the median peak factors reverse the sofa comparison (Table S4). The driving-pressure limit is the largest rise measured while

passing flatus; straining can exceed it, and without the limit the sofa comparison favours the audible passage more strongly.

6 Conclusion

- *Routing.* The body's convective boundary layer takes a slow release and lets a fast one pass, so the momentum of a release next to a body decides which nose it reaches. On a sofa the silent release rises behind the releaser to the ceiling; between two standing people both releases rise between them; in a closed lift the silent release goes straight to the person standing behind the releaser.

- *Physics says it depends.* While two releases of the same gas are carried passively by the same flow, the slower one never gives a higher peak. With passages as emitted at physiological driving pressures, which passage is stronger when both are smelled depends on where the noses are: on a sofa the audible one, twice as often as the silent one but within the numerical uncertainty; in a closed lift, for the person behind the releaser, the silent one (55 against 33% of pairs), in every variation tested, while for those beside the releaser it is the audible one. Between standing people neither is smelled.

- *Memory says mostly.* A silent passage is noticed only if it is smelled, and this selection alone can explain the belief: among remembered pairs the silent passage seems worse in 91% (attentive) to 98% (distracted) of comparisons. The explanation predicts that releasers hold the belief less firmly than bystanders and that people without a sense of smell never remember a silent passage.

Statements and Declarations

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Competing interests The author has no competing interests to declare that are relevant to the content of this article.

Ethics approval and consent Not applicable: this work involved no human or animal participants. The cross-cultural survey uses published sources only.

Data and code availability Code, parameters with their sources (`params/params.yaml`), processed data such as the archived nose-probe series, and the scripts behind every figure and table are openly available at `https://github.com/ccy5123/sbd`; the repository's `README.md` lists the source files of each result. Supplementary text, figures and tables are provided in Online Resource 1.

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Author contributions C.Y.J.: conceptualization, data curation, formal analysis, investigation, methodology, software, validation, visualization, writing—original draft, writing—review and editing.

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